KITCHEN & *KETTLE*

A Simple Life

A guide to doing less, with more intention.

WORKS BECAUSE IT WORKS.

The Pressure to Change

We're constantly being told to change our lives. New habits, new products, new routines — every feed is full of health influencers, DIYers, and homesteaders telling us to do something different than what we're already doing.

Some of this is genuinely good advice, but the volume is the problem. When we're always listening to the next thing we need to change, we rush out and buy the thing, try to implement a new habit, and attempt five different skills all at once. This pace leads to failure — not because we're not trying hard enough, but because no one can implement twenty new things at the same time.

This guide is about subtraction: fewer products, fewer inputs, fewer voices. The goal isn't minimalism as an aesthetic — it's making space for what actually works.

> **Honest note:** Simplifying is harder than accumulating. Buying a new tool feels productive. Getting rid of one doesn't. That's why we keep adding and wonder why life feels heavier. This guide won't fix that overnight, but it will give you permission to stop.

The pages that follow are swaps, principles, and things to let go of. Use what fits and ignore the rest. The point isn't to follow a system — it's to give yourself room to breathe.

NOTES

In the Kitchen

Fewer tools, more cooking. The best kitchen isn't the most equipped — it's the one where you can find everything and use everything.

MASON JARS DO EVERYTHING

Invest in a couple cases of mason jars even if you don't plan on canning. They store dry goods, they're your water bottle, they hold leftovers — I use mine for so many things, and I haven't bought a reusable water bottle in years. One jar replaces a cupboard full of specialty containers.

REPLACE THE DISPOSABLES

Stainless steel where you can, beeswax wraps instead of plastic wrap, foil when it makes sense, silicone mats instead of parchment. None of these are perfect replacements for every single use case, but together they'll cut your disposable spending by most of it.

ONE BREWER, NOT A COLLECTION

A french press makes both tea and coffee, which means you don't need a tea bag drawer, an infuser basket, a pour-over cone, and three different steeping vessels. Pick the one that does both jobs and let the rest go.

YOU DON'T NEED EIGHT OILS

Pick two or three you actually use. Olive oil for most things, a neutral oil for high heat, and maybe one finishing oil if you truly love it. The rest sit in the cupboard going rancid while you reach for the same bottle every time.

> **Go deeper:** Learn to preserve your groceries instead of throwing them away. The Seasonal Preservation Calendar walks you through what to put by each month. Grow perennial herbs — they come back every year and ask almost nothing of you. The Survival Garden Basics guide covers which ones earn their space.

NOTES

Bath & Body

Soap is soap. The rest is marketing.

BAR OVER PUMP

Plastic hand soap pumps create waste and cost more over time, and a simple bar of soap does the same job — just rub your brush on it and scrub. No foaming dispenser, no special tray, no subscription refills showing up at your door.

FREE & CLEAR

Scents and colors in soap are decoration, not function. If your skin is reactive — and many people's is without realizing it — strip it back to nothing. The right soap cleans. That's the whole job.

SIMPLIFY THE ROUTINE

One simple bar for washing. One or two moisturizers that actually work — tallow balm and jojoba oil cover most of what skin needs — and one essential oil if you like scent. I use only lavender in my tallow; it's the most skin-safe oil, and one bottle lasts a long time.

> **Honest note:** It's a lot of pressure to make all of your own body care products. Experimenting with different soap recipes, sourcing ingredients, testing batches, dealing with failures — it's exhausting and it wastes money. Handmade soap isn't automatically more sustainable than commercial; ingredient sourcing matters, and small-batch production isn't always more efficient. Supporting brands that do the right thing takes the burden off your shoulders and helps out the good guys.

> **Go deeper:** The Simple Body Care Guide walks through a complete routine with the fewest possible products — what to buy, what to make, and what's not worth your mixing bowl.

NOTES

Around the House

Less under the sink. Fewer bottles. Same clean house.

SHOP CLOTHS OVER PAPER TOWELS

A stack of shop cloths replaces paper towels for almost everything. They absorb more, cost pennies per use over their lifetime, and you just toss them in the wash. Keep a roll of paper towels around for truly gross jobs, but one roll will last you months instead of days.

SKIP THE DRYER SHEETS

Dryer sheets coat your clothes in chemicals to simulate softness — you don't need them. If static is a problem in winter, wool dryer balls do the same job without the residue, and they last for years.

FEWER CLEANING PRODUCTS

You don't need a different spray bottle for every surface in your home. A simple all-purpose cleaner covers most of it, a mild abrasive handles tough spots, and something for glass if you care about streaks. That's three products where most homes have fifteen.

> **Honest note:** The cleaning aisle is designed to make you feel like each surface needs its own specialized formula. It doesn't. Most of what's in those bottles is water, fragrance, and color — the active ingredients overlap heavily.

> **Go deeper:** The Simple Homekeeping Guide covers a complete cleaning system built around a handful of ingredients — no marketing, no fragrance, just what works.

NOTES

The Diaper Bag Rule

One good thing that does many jobs beats five specialized things that each do one.

Thinking about buying a new purse? Get a diaper bag instead. They've come a long way — really cute designs, insulated lining, built to endure. More convenient compartments for all your things, and you can carry food and snacks without worrying about a spill.

This principle applies everywhere. Look for the one thing that does the most:

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1. The **mason jar** stores, transports, preserves, measures, and serves. It replaces water bottles, storage containers, vases, and shakers.
2. The **french press** makes coffee, tea, cold brew, and infused waters. It replaces a drip machine, a tea strainer, and a dedicated cold brew pitcher.
3. The **shop cloth** wipes counters, scrubs dishes, dries hands, and polishes glass. It replaces paper towels, dish sponges, microfiber cloths, and disposable wipes.
4. The **simple bar of soap** cleans hands, face, and body. It replaces hand soap, body wash, facial cleanser, and three different bottles in the shower.

Before buying something new, ask: *does something I already own do this job?* Most of the time, the answer is yes.

> **Honest note:** This isn't about never buying anything. It's about buying fewer things that each do more. The diaper bag costs more than a basic purse, but it replaces the purse, the lunch bag, the snack carrier, and the emergency kit you'd otherwise buy separately. Sometimes spending more on one thing saves more in the long run.

NOTES

The Noise

Turn down the volume. Most of what you're being told to do, you don't need to do.

Cut out or reduce social media — it's exhausting being constantly told to change your life. Health influencers, DIYers, and homesteaders are always pushing us to do something different because there's huge pressure on them to constantly produce something new, different, and click-worthy. That's how the platforms reward them. But the volume we're being fed leads to failure.

Here's a way out:

JOURNAL YOUR TOP THREE

Sit down and write out the three things you actually care about — not what you think you should care about, not what your feed tells you matters, but what you, in your actual life, want to invest in. Really think about it. This list becomes your filter for everything that follows.

UNFOLLOW EVERYONE WHO DOESN'T SERVE THOSE

This is the hard part. Unfollow anyone who doesn't provide real value toward those three priorities — the cooking account you never cook from, the homesteader whose life looks beautiful but whose advice you'll never use, the organizer whose system you bought and never opened. Let them go.

FOLLOW ONE SOURCE PER INTEREST

I was following about five different homesteading channels. Now I follow only the one that brings the most value, and I no longer feel the constant pressure to keep up with all five telling me what I need to do this season. One voice is enough. More than one is noise.

> **Honest note:** This will feel uncomfortable. You'll worry you're missing something. But you were already missing most of it — you were just feeling guilty about it. Now you're missing it on purpose, and that's different.

NOTES

The DIY Trap

You don't have to make everything. Supporting good brands is not a failure of principles.

There's a lot of pressure in homesteading and DIY culture to make all of your own things — soap, bread, cleaners, clothes, furniture. It adds up fast, and the message underneath it all is subtle but clear: if you're buying it, you're not trying hard enough. That's a trap, and here's why.

EXPERIMENTING IS EXPENSIVE

Trying different soap recipes, sourcing ingredients, testing batches, dealing with failures — it drains time and money. A well-made commercial bar from a brand that sources responsibly isn't a compromise. It's a smart decision that gives you your Saturday back.

HANDMADE ISN'T AUTOMATICALLY MORE SUSTAINABLE

Ingredient sourcing matters, and small-batch production isn't always more efficient than industrial processes that minimize waste. The "handmade equals better" equation skips a lot of math.

FOCUS ON WHAT PRODUCES

Put your energy into things that give back year after year: a few perennial herbs, a small garden that actually feeds you, skills that store food for winter instead of decorating your countertop for Instagram. Depth over breadth, every time.

> **Go deeper:** The Survival Garden Basics guide focuses on what grows well, stores well, and earns its space — no novelty crops. My recipe cards help you master a handful of recipes instead of chasing new ones every week.

NOTES

You're already doing enough.

The goal isn't to optimize every corner of your life. It's to clear enough space that the things you actually care about have room to breathe.

Subtract. Unfollow. Use the diaper bag. Let the rest go.

Kitchen *& Kettle*

Works because it works.

GUIDES WORTH YOUR TIME

SIMPLE BODY CARE GUIDE

A complete routine with the fewest possible products. What to buy, what to make, and what's not worth your mixing bowl.

SIMPLE HOMEKEEPING GUIDE

A cleaning system built around a handful of ingredients — no marketing, no fragrance, no fifteen bottles under the sink.

SURVIVAL GARDEN BASICS

What grows well, stores well, and earns its space. No novelty crops, no complicated systems.

RECIPE CARDS

A small collection of cards for the recipes you actually make — master a handful instead of chasing new ones.

SEASONAL PRESERVATION CALENDAR

What to put by each month, so you preserve groceries instead of throwing them away.

FIRST AID CHECKLIST

What you actually need in your kit — no filler, no panic buys, just the supplies that matter.

AVAILABLE AT *KITCHEN & KETTLE* ON ETSY